CMM 315 · CRISIS COMMUNICATION · FALL 2024 · SPRING HILL COLLEGE

ABOUT THIS PIECE

Self-reflection: crisis simulation

Katherine Conklin

WHAT IT IS

A reflection on a class crisis-communication simulation, a hospital cyberattack, where I played the Community Groups and Brand Ambassador role.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How image repair and attribution theories shaped the response, and what I would do differently.

Self-reflection: Crisis simulation experience

Crisis Communications simulation, Fall 2024 · Katherine Conklin

The Crisis Communications simulation presented a unique opportunity to apply theoretical concepts in a realistic and high-pressure environment. Acting as the Community Groups and Brand Ambassador, I was tasked with fostering positive public perception and building trust with the community during a cyberattack that locked the hospital's systems and disrupted patient care. This paper reflects on the readings that informed my decisions, the aspects of the simulation I enjoyed and found challenging, what I would do differently, and my key takeaways from both the simulation and the overall course.

Informative readings

The readings assigned throughout this course provided a strong foundation for our crisis response strategies during the simulation. Benoit's Image Repair Theory was particularly useful in framing our approach to communication. Our press release employed defeasibility to highlight that the cyberattack was beyond the hospital's control, while bolstering reinforced the hospital's ongoing commitment to patient care. These strategies aligned with Benoit's idea that emphasizing positive aspects and shifting focus can help maintain an organization's reputation (Benoit, 1997).

Similarly, Coombs' Attribution Theory influenced our focus on transparency and stakeholder engagement. By maintaining open communication with the public and expressing gratitude to staff, patients, and partners, we aimed to minimize reputational damage and foster goodwill (Coombs, 2007). This was evident in initiatives like offering flu shots, hosting blood drives, and actively promoting the hospital's role in the community.

Additionally, readings on the erosion of public trust in healthcare during the COVID-19 pandemic provided valuable context for addressing community concerns about the hospital's cybersecurity and overall reliability. Research from Taylor and Moffat (2023) emphasized that transparency and proactive outreach are critical to rebuilding trust in healthcare institutions, which informed our approach to community engagement.

Enjoyment and challenges

Most enjoyable part

One of the most fulfilling aspects of the simulation was collaborating with my peers to develop creative and impactful solutions. Initiatives like flu shot tents, wellness programs, and the "Together We Help, Together We Heal" campaign allowed us to directly address community needs while rebuilding trust in the hospital. Seeing these ideas come to life and align with our broader crisis response goals was particularly rewarding.

Least enjoyable part

Conversely, navigating the challenges of inconsistent messaging during press conferences was frustrating. Our spokesperson's contradictory statements about patient relocation created confusion and undermined the hospital's credibility. For example, the spokesperson initially stated that no patients would be moved,

but later suggested that patient evaluations for relocation might occur. This highlighted the importance of clear, consistent communication, a lesson I will carry forward into future professional settings.

Another difficulty was my limited participation in some group decisions, which left me feeling less connected to the overall process. This experience underscored the importance of staying actively engaged in collaborative projects, particularly in high-stakes situations like crisis management.

Real-life comparison

In a real-life crisis scenario, both the rewarding and challenging aspects of the simulation would likely be magnified. The stakes would be higher, with real lives and reputations on the line. However, the collaborative and problem-solving skills developed in the simulation would remain invaluable. The experience reinforced my belief that preparation, teamwork, and adaptability are critical in managing real-world crises.

Potential improvements

If given another chance, I would approach the simulation with a greater focus on proactive involvement. As the Community Groups and Brand Ambassador, I could have contributed more to crafting targeted campaigns for tertiary audiences, such as local businesses and surrounding communities. Developing clearer, audience-specific messaging would have strengthened our outreach efforts and helped rebuild trust more effectively.

Additionally, I would advocate for a more structured communication plan to prevent contradictions like those seen during the press conferences. Preparing the spokesperson with detailed talking points and anticipated questions would have ensured consistency and reduced public confusion. By taking a more active role in these areas, I could have contributed to a more cohesive and impactful crisis response.

Key takeaways from the simulation

The simulation provided several critical lessons about crisis communication. First, transparency and consistency are essential for maintaining trust during a crisis. Our decision to prioritize honest communication through press releases and regular updates demonstrated the value of clear messaging.

Second, the simulation highlighted the importance of collaborative problem-solving. Initiatives like flu shot tents and wellness programs emerged from group discussions and exemplified how teamwork can lead to innovative solutions. However, the experience also showed that effective collaboration requires active participation from all team members, a point I aim to improve upon in the future.

Finally, the simulation underscored the need for proactive crisis planning. The lack of a pre-existing plan for a cyberattack forced us to make reactive decisions, which introduced challenges and inefficiencies. Developing comprehensive crisis plans that address a wide range of scenarios is crucial for ensuring a swift and effective response.

Key takeaways from the course

Beyond the simulation, this course offered invaluable insights into crisis communication strategies and their real-world applications. Theoretical frameworks like Benoit's Image Repair Theory and Coombs' Attribution Theory provided a solid foundation for understanding how to manage reputational risks and stakeholder relationships (Benoit, 1997; Coombs, 2007). These theories will serve as essential tools in my future career.

The course also emphasized the critical role of trust and public perception in crisis management. Whether dealing with patients, employees, or external stakeholders, maintaining trust is fundamental to navigating crises effectively. Additionally, the course reinforced the importance of ethical decision-making, particularly in scenarios where difficult choices, such as refusing to pay a ransom, must be made.

Finally, the course highlighted the balance between strategic communication and empathy. Engaging with stakeholders on a personal level, as we did through community initiatives, can make a significant difference in how organizations are perceived during crises.

Conclusion

The Crisis Communications simulation was a transformative learning experience that deepened my understanding of crisis management and the importance of collaboration, transparency, and proactive planning. While there were challenges, such as inconsistent messaging and limited participation, the simulation provided valuable insights into the complexities of crisis communication. Moving forward, I am confident that the lessons learned from this simulation and course will serve as a strong foundation for handling real-world crises with integrity and effectiveness.

References

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- Coombs, W. T. (2007). *Protecting Organization Reputations During a Crisis: The Development and Application of Situational Crisis Communication Theory.* Corporate Reputation Review, 10(3), 163–176.
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